

China First-Time Visitor Checklist

A printable 3-page checklist for visa or transit checks, payment setup, apps, internet, transport, hotel addresses, food ordering, and arrival-day backups.

How to use this checklist

Complete page 1 before you fly. Use page 2 on arrival day. Screenshot page 3 for hotel, taxi, restaurant, and emergency moments.

Pre-flight checklist

- ☐ Check visa or visa-free transit eligibility with official sources for your passport and route.
- ☐ Confirm passport validity and keep the same passport details across flights, hotels, trains, and bookings.
- ☐ Book hotels that can register foreign passport holders and save each hotel address in Chinese.
- ☐ Choose an internet plan before arrival: roaming, eSIM, local SIM, or pocket Wi-Fi.
- ☐ Install Alipay, WeChat, translation, maps, ride-hailing, and train support before departure.
- ☐ Save flights, hotels, trains, insurance, onward tickets, and attraction confirmations offline.
- ☐ Bring one main card, one backup card, and a small RMB cash reserve for arrival day.
- ☐ Pack a power bank, charging cable, medicine basics, tissues, hand sanitizer, and walking shoes.

Official checks before booking

- ☐ Visa and entry: China National Immigration Administration - <https://en.nia.gov.cn/>
- ☐ Consular notices: Ministry of Foreign Affairs or your local Chinese embassy page.
- ☐ Trains: China Railway 12306 - <https://www.12306.cn/en/>
- ☐ Planning support: <https://www.firstchinatripkit.com>

Arrival Day, Payment, Apps, and Transport

The first-day goal is simple: get connected, reach the hotel, make payment work, eat something easy, and sleep.

Arrival day checklist

- ☐ Turn on mobile data or connect to airport Wi-Fi before leaving the terminal.
- ☐ Open your hotel booking and Chinese address before joining a taxi, metro, train, or ride-hailing queue.
- ☐ Test payment with a low-pressure purchase such as water, coffee, or a convenience store snack.
- ☐ Avoid a prepaid night activity if immigration, baggage, or transfer time took longer than expected.
- ☐ Ask hotel staff to confirm your Chinese address and nearest useful landmark.

Payment setup checklist

- ☐ Alipay installed, logged in, and card added.
- ☐ WeChat Pay attempted as a backup if your account and card setup allow it.
- ☐ Small RMB cash backup ready for taxis, data failures, or app verification problems.
- ☐ Physical card available for hotels, deposits, and larger merchants that accept cards.
- ☐ Phone battery and data checked before taxis, restaurants, and train station transfers.

Essential apps checklist

Need	App setup reminder
Payment	Alipay first; WeChat Pay as backup if available.
Maps	Save Chinese hotel and station addresses.
Translation	Download offline Chinese and test camera translation.
Ride-hailing	Check pickup point names before late-night use.
Train	Screenshot passport-linked confirmations and station names.
Offline backups	Passport copy, bookings, insurance, and emergency contacts.

Common arrival-day mistake

Trying to solve payment, data, transport, and sightseeing at the same time. Fix phone, payment, hotel, and food first.

Address, Emergency, and Food Phrase Cards

Show Chinese characters when pronunciation is hard. Keep this page saved in your phone photos.

Hotel address card

Field	Write it here
Hotel English name	_____
Hotel Chinese name	_____
Chinese address	_____
Hotel phone	_____
Nearest metro or landmark	_____

Emergency phrases

English	Chinese	Pinyin
I need help.	我需要帮助。	Wo xu yao bang zhu.
Please call the police.	请帮我报警。	Qing bang wo bao jing.
Please call an ambulance.	请帮我叫救护车。	Qing bang wo jiao jiu hu che.
I lost my passport.	我的护照丢了。	Wo de hu zhao diu le.
I do not speak Chinese.	我不会说中文。	Wo bu hui shuo Zhong wen.

Food ordering phrases

English	Chinese	Pinyin
Less spicy, please.	请少辣。	Qing shao la.
No spicy, please.	请不要辣。	Qing bu yao la.
I do not eat pork.	我不吃猪肉。	Wo bu chi zhu rou.
Can I pay with Alipay?	可以用支付宝吗？	Ke yi yong Zhi Fu Bao ma?
Takeaway, please.	请打包。	Qing da bao.

Emergency note

Common emergency numbers in China include 110 for police, 120 for ambulance, and 119 for fire. Ask hotel staff for help if unsure.